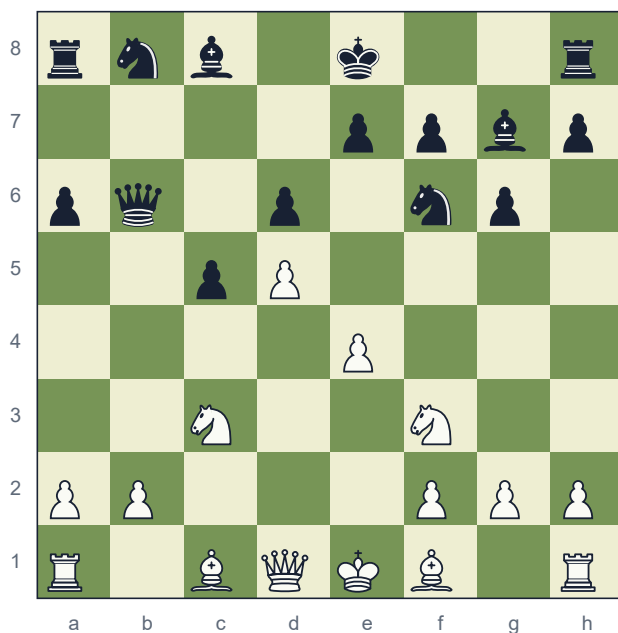


Benko Gambit: the 5.b6 practical decline

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 b5 4.cxb5 a6 5.b6

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Return the b-pawn on terms that reduce Black's familiar open-file compensation. 5.b6 is a practical repertoire choice; it does not refute the Benko.



Main-line anchor - White to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

By advancing the captured pawn to b6, White avoids the standard accepted structure with open a- and b-files against the queenside. Black still has active pieces and a central minority.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black can capture with the queen or knight, or delay the recapture. ...g6, ...Bg7 and ...d6 remain natural development.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Do not mix 5.b6 with accepted-Benko advice about defending an extra pawn on a6.
2. The d5 pawn is your useful space advantage; support it and develop.
3. A returned pawn can buy easier development and reduce the opponent's prepared initiative.

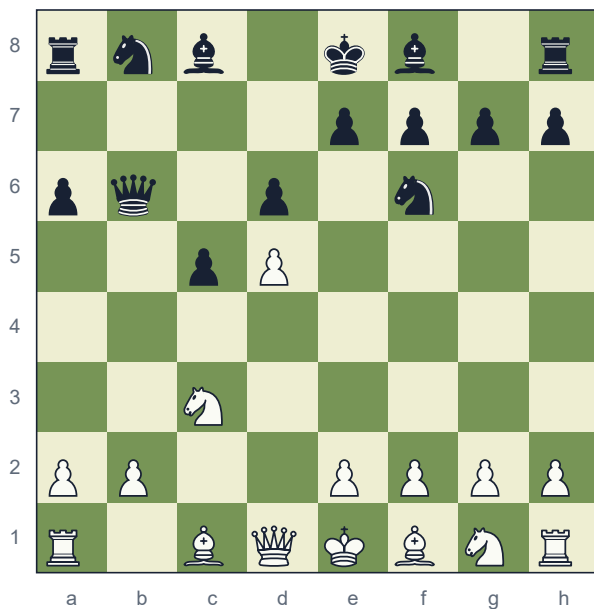
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Black recaptures with the queen

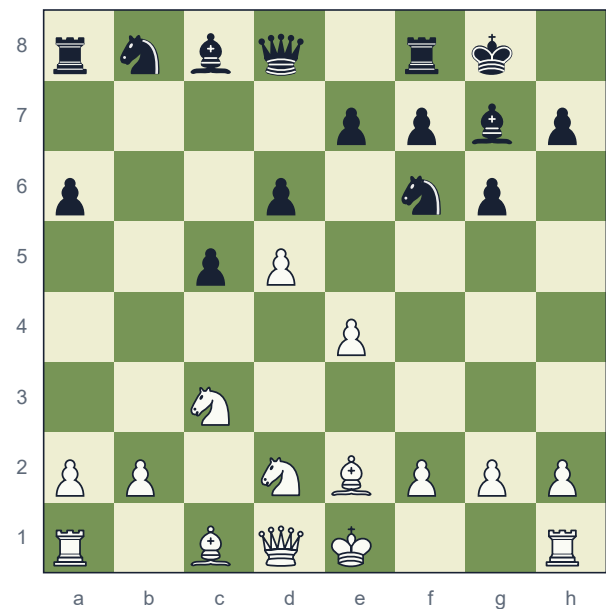
STUDY LINE 17-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. b6 Qxb6 6. Nc3 d6 7. e4 g6 8. Nf3 Bg7 9. Be2 O-O 10. Nd2 Qd8

Selected anchor ends with 8... Bg7. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White has returned material but kept central space. The queen on b6 can become a target for useful developing moves.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the bishops and castle. A timely Nd2-c4 can question the queen, but verify the central tactics first.

WATCH FOR

Do not chase the queen while abandoning d5 or e4.

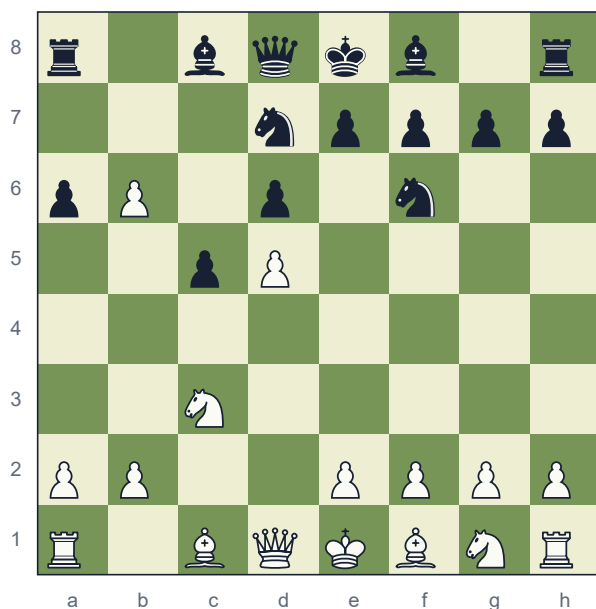
REMEMBER Return the pawn and build a healthy center.

02 Black recaptures with the knight

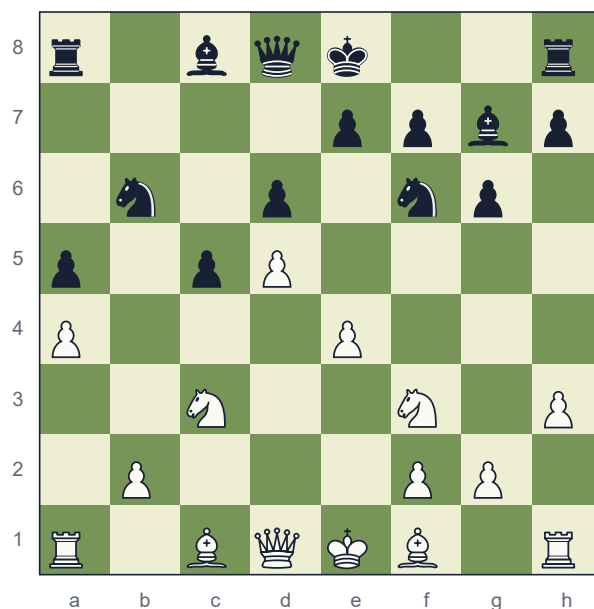
STUDY LINE 17-02

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. b6 d6 6. Nc3 Nbd7 7. e4 Nxb6 8. Nf3 g6 9. h3 Bg7 10. a4 a5

Selected anchor ends with 8. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The knight route costs time but develops a useful piece. White uses the time to occupy the center.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Complete development and compare the value of a4 with improving a bishop. Watch ...e6 against d5.

WATCH FOR

The b6 knight can return to c4 or a4. A queenside pawn move may give it a target.

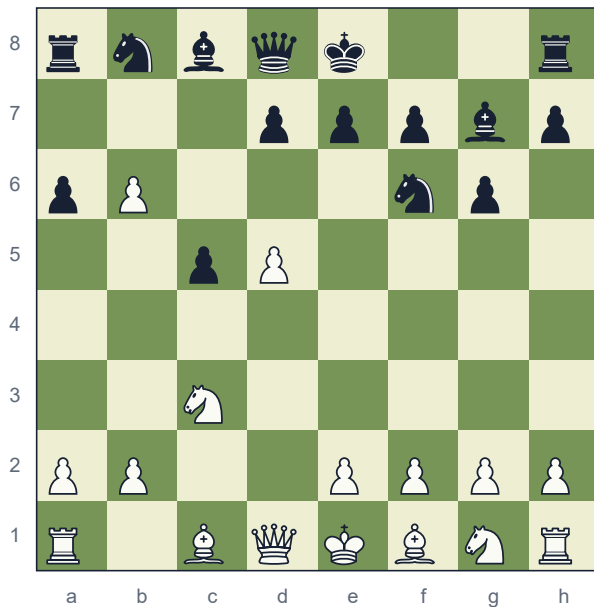
REMEMBER Use Black's recapture tempi for development.

03 Black develops before recovering b6

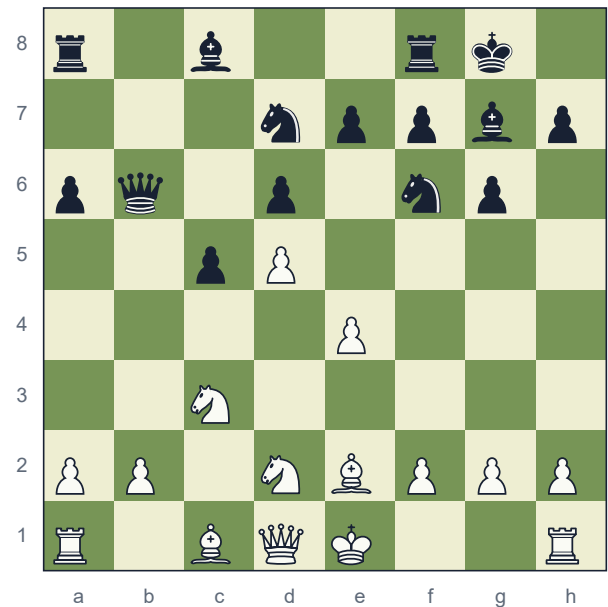
STUDY LINE 17-03

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. b6 g6 6. Nc3 Bg7 7. e4 O-O 8. Nf3 Qxb6 9. Nd2 d6 10. Be2 Nbd7

Selected anchor ends with 8. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White continues normal development instead of trying to defend b6 at any cost. The advanced pawn can be surrendered if protecting it slows the army.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bring out the bishops and castle. Make Black prove compensation in the center, not in a familiar accepted-gambit structure.

WATCH FOR

A pawn far from home is often a distraction. Do not move the queen repeatedly to defend it.

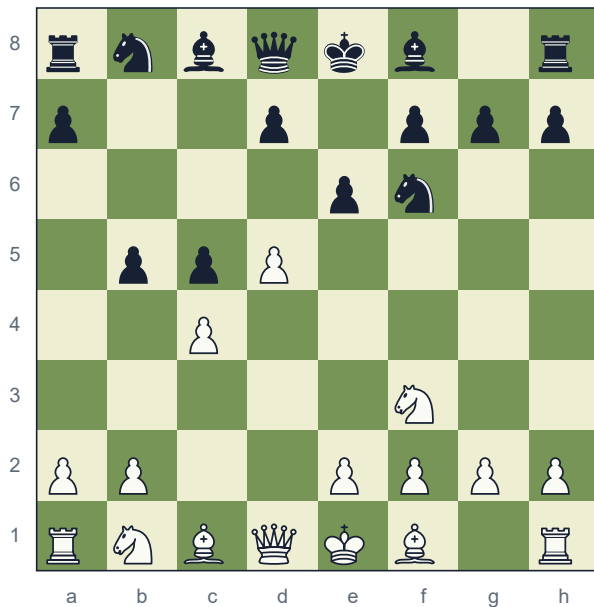
REMEMBER Your center matters more than the temporary b6 pawn.

04 The ...e6 move is a different gambit

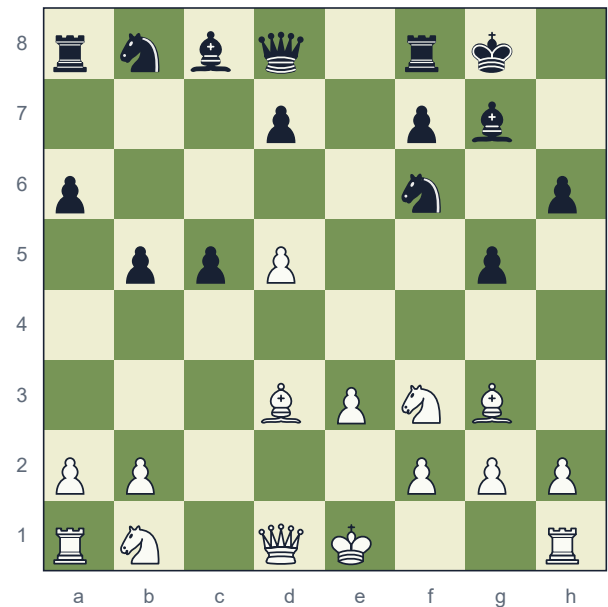
STUDY LINE 17-04

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. Nf3 e6 5. Bg5 exd5 6. cxd5 h6 7. Bh4 g5 8. Bg3 Bg7 9. e3 a6 10. Bd3 O-O

Selected anchor ends with 5. Bg5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

This move order is related to the Blumenfeld family. Bg5 develops while retaining central tension instead of treating every ...b5 as a Benko.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

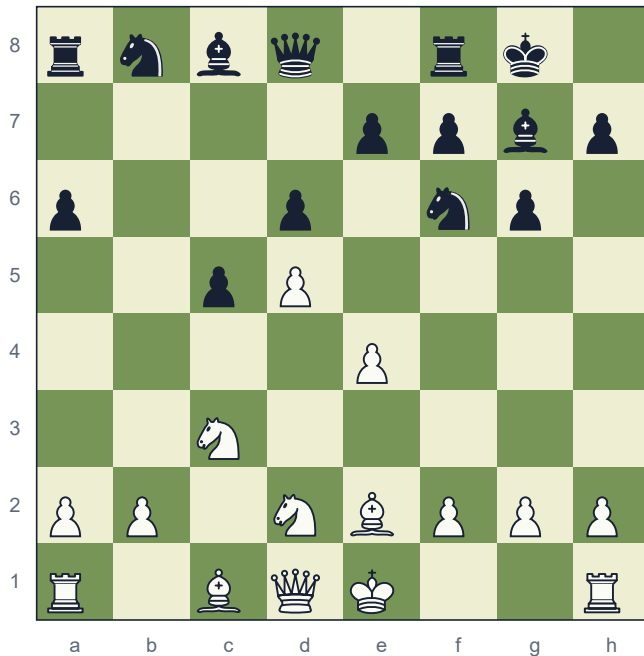
Use the Blumenfeld lesson in Booklet 18. Central exchanges and the f6 pin determine the correct continuation.

WATCH FOR

Do not apply the 5.b6 recipe when you have not captured on b5.

REMEMBER Name the center before choosing the gambit response.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

By advancing the captured pawn to b6, White avoids the standard accepted structure with open a- and b-files against the queenside. Black still has active pieces and a central minority.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black can capture with the queen or knight, or delay the recapture. ...g6, ...Bg7 and ...d6 remain natural development.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the bishops and castle. A timely Nd2-c4 can question the queen, but verify the central tactics first.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.